

PEARLS OF GREAT PRICE

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Matthew 13:45-46 (NKJV) *"Again, the kingdom of heaven is like a merchant seeking beautiful pearls, 46 who, when he had found one pearl of great price, went and sold all that he had and bought it."*

INTRO: Jesus used a variety of visual effects to get His point across. He was a master communicator and He used a technique of teaching called parables. The word parable is derived from the Greek verb paraballo, and means *"to lay by the side of, or to compare something with a likeness, or similitude."* (New Unger's Bible Dictionary) In common terms a parable is a common story which points to common things to teach a Kingdom Principle.

Matthew 13 is almost entirely devoted to a collection of parables. In this collection of parables there is a common thread which runs through each of them, the subject matter is the affect of the Word of God on the life of believers. More specifically it comes down to

the rise and fall of Christian faith in the life of a believer.

Of all the parables listed in Matthew 13, this one is probably the most obvious when it comes to interpretation, but there are a few things I want to highlight.

When we hear the word pearl it doesn't really register with us what is going on because in our culture a pearl is a beautiful, expensive, coveted piece of jewelry.

On the other hand, to this Jewish audience a pearl had very little value; it was actually shocking from a Hebrew standpoint that someone would sell all he had to buy a pearl because a Hebrew person wouldn't walk across the street to pick up pearls if they were being given away.

On the other hand pearls were an expensive commodity in places such as Egypt as well as the ancient city of Nineveh. The Hebrews looked upon those outside their race as dogs, so the fact that the Egyptians and the Ninevites valued the pearl mattered not to the Hebrews.

Also, consider this, Jesus is speaking to fishermen (disciples) and they hated oysters because the oysters were responsible for tearing up their nets, therefore they avoided oysters at all costs.

With this in mind it must have been a tremendous shock to the Disciples as well as this Jewish audience to hear Jesus speaking of a person selling all he has to purchase a pearl.

In this parable: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The merchantman is Jesus...
- The oyster is the world...
- The many pearls the merchantman seeks are potential believers...
- The pearl of great price is the church...

I. THE MERCHANTMAN IS JESUS...

Jesus came to this world to save lost humanity.

Think of what He gave up to have the opportunity for redemption: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- He gave up heaven for earth... John 1:1-12 (NKJV) *“In the beginning was the*

Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.2 He was in the beginning with God.3 All things were made through Him, and without Him nothing was made that was made.4 In Him was life, and the life was the light of men.5 And the light shines in the darkness, and the darkness did not comprehend it. 6 There was a man sent from God, whose name was John.7 This man came for a witness, to bear witness of the Light, that all through him might believe.8 He was not that Light, but was sent to bear witness of that Light.9 That was the true Light which gives light to every man coming into the world.10 He was in the world, and the world was made through Him, and the world did not know Him.11 He came to His own, and His own did not receive Him.12 But as many as received Him, to them He gave the right to become children of God, to those who believe in His name:"

- He took upon Himself the restrictions of a mere mortal... Hebrews 4:14-16 (NKJV)
"Seeing then that we have a great High Priest who has passed through the heavens, Jesus the Son of God, let us hold fast our confession.15 For we do

not have a High Priest who cannot sympathize with our weaknesses, but was in all points tempted as we are, yet without sin.¹⁶ Let us therefore come boldly to the throne of grace, that we may obtain mercy and find grace to help in time of need.”

- He who knew no sin became sin for us...
2 Corinthians 5:21 (NKJV) ***“For He made Him who knew no sin to be sin for us, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him.”***

II. THE OYSTER IS THE WORLD...

The pearl is the only stone that is a by-product of a living organism. I do not know of one other kind of stone that evolves from another living organism. Look at how a pearl is produced. *A pearl is born out of suffering.* In this world there is suffering for as far as the eye can see. This world can be brutal.

A spec of sand or parasite makes its way into the oyster. The oyster is a living organism and this intruder brings great pain to the oyster. To protect itself, the oyster secretes a substance known as mother-of-pearl, or aragonite (nacre). This secretion surrounds the sand or parasite and layer by SLOW layer the wound of

intrusion becomes a valuable jewel, better known as a pearl.

The pain involved in the development of a pearl is excruciating so **the pearl is quite literally the product of an injured life**. Every person born into this world is born in pain and sin. The pain of childbirth is almost unbearable but the pain inflicted by sin is completely unbearable by mere mortals.

The processes of life can be extremely painful and usually when a person comes to Christ they come as a result of some type of crisis.

Contrary to public opinion natural **pearls aren't smooth, they are actually rough in texture and misshaped**. They are never smooth and perfectly round unless created in a lab.

Look at the people God decided to use:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- **Noah** – Got drunk...
- **Abraham** – Had a lying problem and passed it on to his sons...
- **Rahab** – Was a prostitute...
- **David** – Had female troubles and couldn't control his own household...

- **John the Baptist** – Wore a camel skin leisure suit held in place by a leather girdle and ate grasshoppers and honey...
- **Simon Peter** – Was a loud mouth who struggled with his temper and was somewhat of a braggart...
- **Peter, James and John** – Three crude fishermen who had little to no professionalism...

The merchantman knows when he finds a pearl some shaping will be needed.

III. THE MANY PEARLS THE MERCHANTMAN SEEKS ARE INDIVIDUAL BELIEVERS...

When the merchantman found what he was looking for he gave all to purchase the pearl of great price! John 3:16 (KJV) ***“For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life.”***

Luke 19:10 (NKJV) ***“The Son of Man has come to seek and to save that which was lost.”***

Romans 5:8-10 (NKJV) ***“But God demonstrates His own love toward us, in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us.9 Much more then, having now been justified by***

His blood, we shall be saved from wrath through Him.10 For if when we were enemies we were reconciled to God through the death of His Son, much more, having been reconciled, we shall be saved by His life.”

1 Peter 3:18 (NKJV) *“For Christ also suffered once for sins, the just for the unjust, that He might bring us to God, being put to death in the flesh but made alive by the Spirit.”*

When all we can see is the intrusion of sin in our lives, Christ sees the opportunity to make a pearl. 1 Peter 2:3-6 (NKJV) *“If indeed you have tasted that the Lord is gracious. 4 Coming to Him as to a living stone, rejected indeed by men, but chosen by God and precious,5 you also, as living stones, are being built up a spiritual house, a holy priesthood, to offer up spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ.6 Therefore it is also contained in the Scripture, “Behold, I lay in Zion A chief cornerstone, elect, precious, And he who believes on Him will by no means be put to shame.”*

Pearls are produced with some shaping needing to be done. The old song say’s “*He’s still working on me.*” The Hemphill’s made popular a song which say’s “*I’m not perfect, just*

forgiven, haven't yet arrived but I'm on my way. Since Jesus saved me and forgave me I can't say I'm perfect but I can say I'm saved."

We are the jewels God desires to place around His Royal Neck to display for the entire world to see. Jeremiah 29:11-12 (NKJV) ***"For I know the thoughts that I think toward you, says the LORD, thoughts of peace and not of evil, to give you a future and a hope. 12 Then you will call upon Me and go and pray to Me, and I will listen to you."*** Jude 24 (NKJV) ***"Now to Him who is able to keep you from stumbling, And to present you faultless Before the presence of His glory with exceeding joy."***

The merchantman (Jesus) is seeking to redeem every single pearl possible.

IV. THE PEARL OF GREAT PRICE IS THE CHURCH...

The pearl of great price is the Church, the corporate body of Christ. **The Church is the crown jewel of the merchantman.** Jesus died to purchase the church. Matthew 16:13-19 (NKJV) ***"When Jesus came into the region of Caesarea Philippi, He asked His disciples, saying, ***'Who do men say that I, the Son of Man, am?'***"***14 So they said, "Some say John

the Baptist, some Elijah, and others Jeremiah or one of the prophets.”¹⁵ He said to them, “But who do you say that I am?”¹⁶ Simon Peter answered and said, “You are the Christ, the Son of the living God.”¹⁷ Jesus answered and said to him, “Blessed are you, Simon Bar-Jonah, for flesh and blood has not revealed this to you, but My Father who is in heaven.¹⁸ “And I also say to you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build My church, and the gates of Hades shall not prevail against it.”

If Christ died to build the Church we should greatly respect the life, ministry, and work of the Church. Since Christ died to build the Church how do you think he views folks who are always attempting to sow discord in the Church?

The Church is the most powerful organism on the planet. Jesus is coming back after the Church. Ephesians 5:25-27 (KJV) “*Husbands, love your wives, even as Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it; ²⁶That he might sanctify and cleanse it with the washing of water by the word, ²⁷That he might present it to himself a glorious church, not having spot, or wrinkle, or any such thing; but that it should be holy and without blemish.*”

The greatest harvest of pearls in the history of the world will occur at the end of this age when Christ returns to harvest the pearls He was looking for in Matthew thirteen. 1

Thessalonians 4:16-19 (NKJV) ***“For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. ¹⁷ Then we who are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And thus we shall always be with the Lord. ¹⁸ Therefore comfort one another with these words.”***

1 Corinthians 15:51-56 (NKJV) ***“Behold, I tell you a mystery: We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed— ⁵² in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, and the dead will be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed. ⁵³ For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality. ⁵⁴ So when this corruptible has put on incorruption, and this mortal has put on immortality, then shall be brought to pass the saying that is written: “Death is swallowed up in victory.”⁵⁵ “O Death, where is your sting, O Hades, where is your victory?” ⁵⁶ The***

sting of death is sin, and the strength of sin is the law. ⁵⁷ But thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.”